



GANDHIAN APPROACH TO LEPROSY SERVICE

a collection of speeches by
VINOBA BHAVE

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BY

VINOBA BHAVE

सप्रेम भेट.

परंधाम प्रकाशन

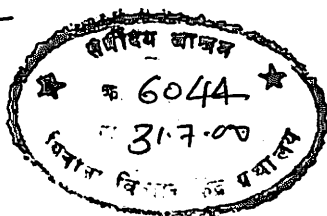
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1984

PARANDHAM PRAKASHAN, PAUNAR, WARDHA

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634 Leper is a word of bad odour. India is perhaps a home of lepers next only to Central Africa. Yet they are as much a part of society as the tallest among us. But the tall absorb our attention though they are least in need of it. The lot of the lepers who are much in need of attention is studied neglect. I am tempted to call it heartless, which it certainly is in terms of non-violence. It is largely the missionary who, be it said to his credit, bestows care on him. The only institution run by an Indian, as a pure labour of love, is by Shri Manohar Diwan near Wardha. It is working under the inspiration and guidance of Shri Vinoba Bhave. If India was pulsating with new life, if we were all in earnest about winning independence in the quickest manner by truthful and non-violent means, there would not be a leper or begger in India uncared for and unaccounted for. In this revised edition I am deliberately introducing the leper as a link in the chain of constructive effort. For, what the leper is in India, that we are, if we will but look about us, for the modern civilised world. Examine the condition of our brethren across the ocean and the truth of my remark will be borne home to us."

Gandhi

The occasion of XII International Leprosy Congress 20-25 th February 1984, is also significant for this publication. The relevance of Gandhian approach has been revived and intensely felt again all over the world as is evident from the overwhelmed enthusiasm and appreciation the film Gandhi received.

This small effort may help this august gathering of leprosy workers from all over the World to understand his vision and thus enlighten our path so as to work out better strategies and better implementation for completely solving the problem of leprosy.

Vinoba Bhave (1895-1982), the principal desciple of Gandhi, regarded as his spiritual heir, is famous for his Land-Gift (Bhoodan) Movement for which he travelled 80,000 Km on foot looking all parts of India for 13 years, spreading the message of Truth, Love and Compassion which resulted in the landed people donating 4.2 million acres of their land for their landless neighbours.

His deep scholarship in the spiritual thought of India made him proclaim the concept of Universal Brotherhood (Jai Jagat). He inspired many in the land to take up acts of compassion and social change amongst which he considered Leprosy work as the foremost. Here in is a collection of thoughts expressed by him on this subject of vital human interest."



**Dr. Ravishankar Sharma, Acharya Vinobaji Bhave
and Shri Baba Amte**



Dr. ShivajiRao Patwardhan with Acharya
Vinoba, Tapovan Amraoti



Manoharji Diwan with Vinobaji : a happy moment
www.vinoba.in

Message from
PRIME MINISTER OF INDIA

We have been helped a lot by the modern medical science in the control of leprosy. Now it is no longer a dreadful disease as before, nor the people afflicted with leprosy need segregation from the rest of the society. The damage and deformities brought about by this disease to a person can also be minimised with the help of plastic surgery and artificial limb installations.

Mahatma Gandhi, Acharya Vinoba Bhave and many other devoted persons have contributed a lot to do away with this evil so as to make the patient feel him-self as a part of the Society and not an out-cast. Let me hope, the ideas and view of Vinobaji regarding leprosy would be carried to the maximum number of people.

My best wishes for successful publication of "Leprosy Service and Vinoba."

New Delhi

Indira Gandhi

18th August 1983.

Translated from Hindi.

PREFACE

Dr. Ravishankar Sharma

Indian history is very ancient. It abounds with mention and analysis of several problems related to man as an individual and the society he lives in. Mention of Leprosy (Kushtha Rog) has been made in the oldest Vedic literature of India. An extensive and detailed description of Leprosy – ‘Kushtha’ – and its treatment is available in ‘Charak’, ‘Sushrut’, ‘Vagbhatta’ etc, which are important ancient treatises on Indian system of medicine. All skin diseases have been referred to as “Kushtha” in these books. But the diseased condition referred to as “Mahakushtha” – ‘Maharog’ only should be taken to mean Leprosy. In one of the Vedas mention has been made regarding Ghosha, the daughter of a sage. She was afflicted with Leprosy which was known by the name “Arjun” then. She became free from the disease through prayer. Vinoba often used to refer regarding Ghosha saying that it is not quite certain whether Ghosha was cured of Leprosy through prayer or not but she most certainly must have freed herself from “Bhava-rog” — attained salvation.

Compassion for all living beings occupies a place of special importance in Indian religion and culture. That, one should have a feeling of love and compassion for all living creatures, has been specially ordained in Indian scriptures and books of learning.

“दया धर्म का मूल है, पाप मूल अभिमान ।
तुलसी दया न छोड़िये, जब लग घट में प्राण ॥”

(Compassion is the basis of religious living and ego is the root of all vices. One should never allow compassion to disappear as long as one is alive)

This has been amply propounded in all old religious literature of India.

सर्वेषां च सुहृद् नित्यम्, सर्वेषां च हिते रताः ।
कर्मणा मनसा वाचा, स धर्म वेद जाजले ॥

(Having always a feeling of love for all and keeping oneself completely engaged in service and good of others – physically, mentally as well as verbally – is what religion is.)

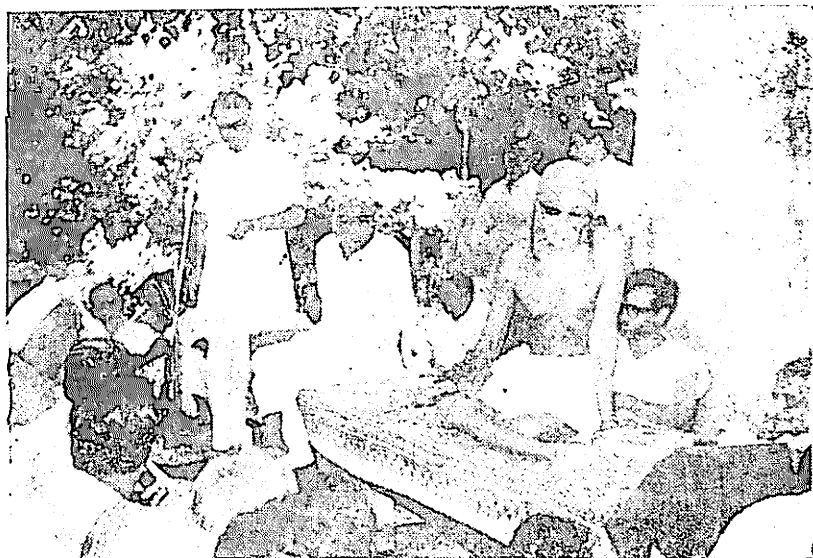
The above saying in the vedas also supports the same thought. But, somehow, during the medieval times the idea of 'Bhoot-daya' – compassion for all living creatures – got narrowed and limited. The importance of human service aspect of this in particular was allowed to be ignored. Vinobaji regarded the human service activities of the people of Christian religious faith with great admiration and respect. Jesus Christ occupied a place of very special importance in Vinoba's Life. In this connection he very often used to quote a sentence from Tennison : "Many things are wrought by prayer than what we can think of." He very much appreciated the practice of praying with the patients, generally followed by the Christian missionaries.

At the same time it distressed him to observe that we in India have almost forgotten significance of human service. That people from other countries having different religious faiths come and undertake leprosy service in a country where millions of people are suffering from this disease, while its' own people do not come forward for service in this field– according to him, was something disgraceful and a serious failing on our part. During the present era Swami Ramkrishna and Vivekanand drew the attention of the whole nation towards this failing of ours. They also used the word "Daridra Narayan" (Lord in the form of the poor). In the present times at several places we now see actual human service activities being undertaken alongwith activities towards spiritual upliftment through persuit of wisdom (Vedanta) and devotion to God by organisations such as Ramkrishna mission, Bharat Seva Ashram Sangh etc. Mahatma Gandhi went further and sought to completely eliminate the difference between the inner living through spiritual persuits and the outward life one leads. He gave new inspiration, vision and approach to leprosy service and infact enlarged it's domain to the whole philosophy of living of the mankind at large. Vinoba extended these concepts further and added new ideas and programmes of activities.

The very first Indian missionary voluntary institution to take up Leprosy service in this country was started under inspiration from Vinoba at Dattapur(Wardha). He motivated his very close associate late Shri Manohar Diwan to establish the organisation "Maharogi Seva Mandal" and the Leprosy Service Centre at Dattapur. Vinoba considered the Leprosy Service Centre at Dattapur as a part and extension of his Paunar Ashram itself. He had his own ideas and ways of looking at the activities carried

out at this centre and used to make frequent mention of the same. He used to say that the Dattapur Leprosy Service Centre is the child of the concept of whole village service programme through constructive work. Here the patients would certainly get all the required medical treatment and care but the institution should also pay due emphasis on developing their social, economic, mental and ethical aspects of life. They should not develop a feeling of being inferior, low, dependent for their existence on the charity of others. They should be provided here with the opportunity and training to be able to lead a productive cooperative and religious life based on Yoga. All efforts should be made here so that they are able to secure a place of honour and respect in society. Selfless and devoted workers, inspired for leprosy service, should be prepared here. Brahma Vidya (Knowledge of ultimate reality of life) should be integrated with leprosy service. Vinobaji delivered several talks and held discussions regarding this subject of leprosy, some of which have been reproduced in this booklet.

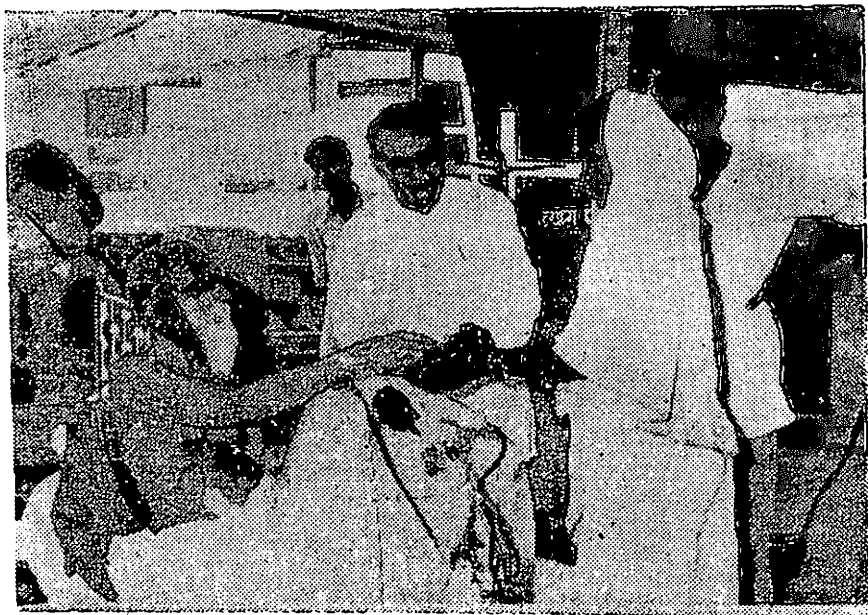
The second large Leprosy service organisation, which is being run by Shivajirao Patwardhan, an old and close associate of Vinoba, is known as "Vidarbha Maharogi Seva Mandal" Tapovan and is located at Amraoti, Maharashtra State. The foundation of this institution was laid by Vinoba in 1949. Vinoba visited Tapovan several times after wards. He used to often refer in his talks a sentence he read engraved there : "We treat ; He cures". God will most certainly bestow his grace and make us succeed in our endeavour if we take up service work with all humility and freedom from all ego. Dr. Shivajirao Patwardhan's inner feeling of urgency and his deep affection for Vinoba often found expression in his occasional verbal onslaughts which were answered to with a deep feeling of devotion and love by him. Vinobaji's address at the inauguration ceremony of Anandvan, (a leprosy institution) Warora, Maharashtra in 1951 is indicative of a step ahead in his thinking process. He said at Warora that Baba Amte's act of establishing this Centre was like that of creating a new "Ramayan". He said that leprosy service was really the work of Lord Rama himself. Hanuman says in Ramayan : "How can I rest until the work ordained by Lord Rama is completed by me ?". Here can be found the source of the deep inner feeling which prompted Baba Amte to establish the leprosy service centre at Warora which is



October 1973 Paunar Ashram : Dr. R. V. Wardekar
with Acharaya Vinoba, addressing the
gathering of leprosy workers



Vinobaji Bhawe at Dattpur February 1981



October 2, 1981 : Acharya Vinoba distributing medicine
to a patient on the occasion of inauguration of
Multi-drug-Therapy programme at Paunar

a valiant achievement of the lame, deformed and mutilated persons. A small seedling of a creeper planted then is growing up to reach the sky. Its fragrance is spreading all over. The subdued voice of those in misery now is being heard the world over. Our hope is that this work would draw the attention of people all over the world and the persons in misery would be accepted as one of them by the human society at large. The institution at Warora has been a source of new inspiration and insight with regard to rehabilitation aspect of leprosy.

It was the fervent desire held by Vinobaji that the institution at Warora named as "Anandvan" may become a centre disseminating the message of "Anand"-Joy-to humanity at large.

Vinobaji remained intimately connected with another institution located at Wardha. - The Gandhi memorial Leprosy Foundation. His views expressed there on several occasions also give us new insights. In Vedic literature mention has been made of 'Prevention and Cure' with regard to diseases. Vinoba said that the Leprosy Foundation's main objective should be prevention of leprosy. To achieve this objective discussions and seminars should be held to suggest ways and means as to how the programme of health education, mass communication, survey, publication and dissemination of new knowledge, organisation of health clinics in villages and training of the workers should best be carried out. It should also take up a specific area where experiments on methods of leprosy control are conducted. Such experimental work would be helpful to others engaged in leprosy Service and the work of the Foundation would become complementary to the leprosy control programme being carried out by actual practical workers in this field elsewhere.

During the year 1955 when Vinoba went to Bihar in connection with his Bhoodan (Land-gift-movement) work he visited the Leprosy Service Centre at Kapasia which was established there by Jayaprakash Narayan. He stayed at Kapasia for one night. The views expressed by him there point towards still newer directions. He stated that leprosy control would not be possible through institutions and organisations working in isolation and exclusively. Leprosy service should become a part and parcel of the general programme of village reconstruction of which the Village-Council should take up full

responsibility. Vinoba stressed that the Village-council itself should take care of the five sections of the village population viz. Aged, Children, Widows, Diseased and Unemployed. The village as a whole should function as one large family. Then only it would become free from all its miseries. Until this is done the Village Self-rule (Gram Swarajya) can not be established. Self Government is far more important than Good - government. These very views were again expressed by him at Santhal Paharia Seva Mandal (Bihar) on seeing the leprosy work which was being conducted there by Shri Gauri Shankar Dalmiya.

At Madhupur (Bihar), during his one day halt, he very closely examined the activities of Leprosy Service being conducted with feeling and concern.

He similarly blessed and inspired the workers of the Gorakhpur Leprosy Service Centre U. P. and the Rajendra Leprosy Service Centre Mairwa, Bihar. These Centres were established on inspiration from Baba Raghavdas, an humble, selfless worker of repute and devoted disciple of Gandhi.

At his own "Ashram" at Paunar Vinobaji addressed several gatherings and meetings of leprosy workers. Besides addressing gatherings and functions at the local, State and National levels, his programme of meetings and discussions with individual visitors and in groups which included persons belonging to Government, National as well as International organisations, delegates to Conferences, etc. constantly went on. At times meetings of leprosy affected persons and meetings of leprosy workers also were arranged at his Paunar Ashram. During his talks in these gatherings he used to say that Gandhiji was the first leprosy service worker in India; Dr. Shivaji Rao Patwadhan the Second; Late Manohar Diwan the third and Baba Amte the fourth. Besides three there are several others known and unknown who have rendered valuable service. When some one asked him about he himself, he at once replied that he served those who were engaged in leprosy service themselves.

After Gandhi it has been Vinoba who drew the attention of people at large towards leprosy service. Not only this, he did his best to give a new direction and momentum to the leprosy control programme in India in-keeping with the present scientific advancement and knowledge made available. Indian Prime-minister Indira Gandhi also has mentioned this in her message

sent for this publication. Vinoba used to stress on the need of tackling the problem of leprosy on global level in which active cooperation of all the nations should be sought. At the same time he also emphasised upon taking up limited areas and implementing the programme intensively, which would result in finding new ideas and ways out of experience gained. Since the last three years an intensive leprosy control programme, known as M. D. R. T., covering the entire Wardha district has been undertaken by the Government. This was inaugurated by Vinobaji on 2-10-1981. This programme of multi-drug-regimen covering the whole district is no doubt a very hopeful event for this region but its success would depend on how well the whole programme is organised and executed with full care, vigilance and spirit of dedication. This programme which may be considered to be the first step towards developing Wardha district as Gandhi district again has been undertaken on inspiration from Vinoba. Even while thinking about Wardha district he always had in his mind the picture of the problem of the country as a whole and the various institutions engaged in tackling the same. This is why he gave all his blessing to the National-Leprosy-Organisation of India and got the idea of equality of all religions introduced in leprosy service work as well. It was his conviction that the days of narrow sectarian religions are now over. So also the political system based on party politics is also now becoming a system of the past. The present age is the age of science and spiritualism. All problems of the world now on would be solved with the help of the union of these. The problems being faced in the leprosy-control programme also can be ultimately solved through union of science and spiritualism only.

The address delivered by Vinoba to the All India Leprosy Conference held in 1973 is an aquisite presentation of and an extensive analysis of the problem of leprosy control in its wholeness in the present day world context. In this address he has highlighted the three main evils of the society and the ways to overcome them. Vinoba generally never gave a prepared address; but this time he had done a pre-thinking and had noted down the points of his speech. His philosophical thinking used to be so clear, original and inspiring that it always maintained its freshness and effectiveness.

The ideas held by Gandhi and Vinoba and their approach to the problem of leprosy stimulated us all and provided the

workers in general with both inspiration as well as direction. This programme has now attained considerable importance at the national level, and at the Government level good, serious and detailed thinking on the strategy for its control has also been now done. A new and comprehensive strategy for effectively tackling the problem in the country as a whole is being formulated. The Govt. of India have made a fairly good financial allocation for its implementation. It has now been resolved to eradicate leprosy from the country by 2000 A. D. Full cooperation of W. H. O has also been assured for this great endeavour. Under such situation it is very important that the leprosy service programme is taken up with missionary spirit and zeal and an atmosphere of dedicated selfless service is created in the institutions engaged in this programme. From this point of view the responsibility of the voluntary service institutions has been further enhanced. The publication of this booklet has been undertaken with the feeling that Vinoba's thoughts and ideas will enable us to effectively implement the programme by providing necessary inspiration as well as guidance. Through out his life he stimulated and led us into this field of service. After discarding the body his spirit will continue to inspire us all the more to carry out this programme more extensively, deeply and effectively.

If the strength of all of us can be properly harnessed for this work there is absolutely no doubt that we shall be able to wipe out this age-old mark of disgrace on humanity.





15th February 1981 : Unveiling the statue of
Manoharji Diwan on his first death anniversary

LEPROSY SERVICE

It is only for the technical experts to speak on eradication of Leprosy ; I am not an expert in this field. It is also true that people here may not be expecting to hear any thing from me in this regard as an expert. I shall express my thoughts on leprosy here only because I am one of the lovers and well-wishers of leprosy service work.

Leprosy Service a Part of Integrated Rural

Service Programme -

You know already that, here at Wardha, since the past 12 years, a small leprosy service institution has been functioning. While undertaking this work through this institution we had no clear-cut concepts nor did we formulate any well thought out plans for action. From 1932 onwards, for two three years, we moved round several villages here in connection with our rural service work we had undertaken. After that, we selected a few villages and started some of our constructive activities according to our own ideas of rural service such as khadi, service to the untouchables, etc. During our visits to these villages we critically looked into the needs and problems faced by the rural people and had regular discussions on ways and means for solving them. We had never imagined that leprosy was such a menacing problem faced by people in this area. Our visits to the villages and close studies of the rural problems there very vividly revealed the magnitude of this melody. Statistics of the prevalence of leprosy in this region have been published by the Government already. The seriousness of the problem as it exists, however, can only be grasped if the figures of statistics presented are multiplied four times. The question then arose as to what should be done about it. We came to the conclusion that leprosy service work in this area must be undertaken. It was imperative. With the intense feeling of my friend Manoharji, leprosy work was then started. His intense feeling also made us acquire some knowledge regarding this disease. At that time leprosy service was not included by Gandhiji in his constructive programme. Still, with our ideas and concept of integrated rural service in our mind, leprosy service automatically emerged as a part of our constructive programme for rural service.

There is no speciality in the programme of leprosy work here. Neither have there been any new discoveries made nor has the programme been very widely extended. In my opinion, however, the speciality in what is being done here is that it is the product and outcome of the integrated rural service work. Voluntary institutions doing leprosy service, other than those run by missionaries, are very few in India. The importance that this institution has earned on this account also may be considered another speciality of this institution.

Antiquity of Leprosy

The spread of this disease is not uniform all over the world. In some countries it is not found at all, while in many others it is a very serious problem. Our country is included among the ones where it is widely prevalent. It has been so since very early times of recorded history. Mention of this disease has also been made in Vedas. One of the sages of the vedic times prays God to invoke his grace saying "Oh God I am expressing my misery through my tears and wailings. Come to my help. Take pity on me and bestow your grace in the manner you did on 'Ghosha' who kept on invoking your mercy and grace to free her self from 'Kushta-Rog' (Leprosy)." It can not definitely be said as to what specific ailment this sage was referring to and was suffering from. It is quite probable that his melody was not physical. May be he was suffering the pangs and misery due to some spiritual ailments of his mind, its conflicts or agony. It also can not be definitely said whether the disease referred to as Leprosy by Ghosha, the other lady sage, was leprosy or it was only Leucoderma - the erroneously so called white leprosy. The word used in the vedas indicates leucoderma while the inference points out towards Leprosy. Whatever may be true, undoubtedly leprosy has been prevalent in India since times immemorial. It is mentioned in the Vedas that the Sage Ghosha freed herself from the disease through her devotion to God and prayer. This faith in prayer is being continued to be held by persons charged with devotional feelings still now since vedic times.

Cause of Leprosy

The use of 'Chalmogra' as the treatment for this disease has been known already here since long, as also, the need for keeping the affected persons segregated from the normal healthy people. Unfortunately, it should be admitted that the idea of segregation

Could not be adopted in practice as anything else and beyond hating and discarding the leprosy victims from the normal society. There is every reason to believe that, among whatever historical reasons there may have been behind the social evil of untouchability, this idea of keeping the leprosy affected persons away must have also been one among them. It is not for me to go in to the causes of leprosy nor do I think it is necessary. Many specialists have already thrown enough light on this aspect, from which it can be concluded that really nothing definite about the same is still known. Some of the less informed and simple minded persons, among whom I include myself as well, attribute some failings in the previous life as the cause of this misery. Scientifically stated it only means that "there has to be some cause or the other" although nothing can be said with absolute certainty. Although the cause or reasons for the ailments of an individual are contained in the individual himself, still, an individual has also to suffer because of the failings or faults of the society as well. Slow implementation of programmes and strategies, unhygienic living conditions, inadequate nutrition and such other common drawbacks play their own part. This is the reason why, in any programme of eradication of a complex disease as leprosy, programmes to solve the commonly associated problems of such general nature should be undertaken as intrinsic part of the strategy.

The Contribution of Christian Religion

India can certainly claim the 'Ownership' of the disease of leprosy, but it is also true that people here did not make any special efforts in the past for its control. Christian missioneries have indeed worked with devotion in this direction. The lesson taught by them through their example in itself is a very big contribution of Christian religion to India. We should acknowledge it with gratitude and should also thankfully ponder over it deeply. We have evolved the very big word - "Bhoot Daya" (Compassion for all living creatures) and have experimented upon vegetarianism and non-violence towards all living creatures. But we forgot that service to the fellow humans is already included as an intrinsic part of "Bhoot daya". The word "Bhoot daya" acquired such a wideness in its connotation that we became completely unaware of our duties in the nearer fields. In contrast to this, the Christian religion used words with limited parlance in

their meaning such as "Humanity" or "Human Service", due to which, the Christians very easily acquired an interest in service to fellow humans and they thought of experimenting on vegetarianism much later. This reveals the tremendous power of words. The word-power however is always limited and hence it is not necessary to change the words. Every one may chose his own word but he should re-inforce its parlance of meaning with its lost and left out field of connotation through his own personal conduct.

Our Attitude of Negligence

The energy of our workers, up till now, was largely spent in ousting the foreign power. Our leaders adopted the method of non-violent resistance in doing so with the result that some constructive programme also was undertaken. But still, the objective being mainly political, all our constructive activities, some how, remained only half-hearted. Consequently the kind of independence we got, and, its condition now, is already so very clearly evident. If we had carried out our constructive programme of work with all our heart and soul, with full devotion, the flame and vigour of our political freedom would have been some what different. Even then there is no point in putting the blame on any one in this regard. With negation and resistance as our main objective and driving force, our constructive work carried out in the manner and it's extent, had to be what it did remain to be. Among the various activities with regard to our constructive programme. our workers devoted their attention more or less to only such fields which helped in uniting and mobilising the masses for political action or pressurising the foreign Government. In such a situation who could think of a non-revolutionary programme of service to humanity such as leprosy work ?

Get Ready For Service

The position now has been changed. We have got rid of the foreign rule now. We shall now accomplish nothing with negation or resistance as our objective. We have now to build up our self-rule, our political freedom, from its very foundation to the top. Our self-government has got to be made into "Ram-Rajya" or the rule of God. If the meaning of Self-rule and independence remains restricted to only freedom from a foreign power and transfer of the same to a handful of persons amongst ourselves,

it could turn out to be "Ravan-Rajya" or the rule of the devil. If we don't want our freedom to be so, we will have to girdle our loins and get determined to dedicate our selves for service to the poor, down-trodden and despised.

Compassionate Selfless Workers Needed

Those, whose thinking is shallow, say that, now since we have our own Government, this would all be taken care of by the Government. But no thinking could be more foolish than this. Without the adoption of service work on an extensive scale by a multitude of selfless workers, it will never be possible for the Government by itself to achieve any thing much in the field such as Leprosy service. No doubt, the Govt. can provide some help and it certainly should do so. But I am sure, this is the field of work for selfless, devoted, service oriented workers mainly.

At the present time such workers charged with love and compassion should come forward in large number for service in this field. This conference would be considered to have been a success if it can prove useful in stimulating people to this end. If such devoted service oriented workers come forward the possible aid from the Government would also be available and it would also be possible to channelise public charity in the desired direction.

We shall have to be clear in our mind as to what help we expect from the Government for success of Leprosy service programme. Promulgation and observance of certain rules, measures to ensure some social control and procedures would be necessary. I would, personally, expect only this much from the Government. I would like the people themselves to provide all the necessary finances. It is not that we lack in the urge and desire for offering charity. It is only that we are not discriminative in our response to it. Charity does not mean just throwing away something by way of charity any where in any manner. People will have to be made to understand that a donation is charity only when it is utilized for a good purpose.

I do not consider this work as particularly difficult. What is important is that a good number of persons should come forward for work. Some false notions regarding Leprosy held commonly will also have to be dispelled. It is generally believed

that work in the field of leprosy means inviting a very big danger for one's own self. It should be made very clear to everyone that it is really not so. No doubt there is some little danger, but of one swears that he would never take any risk in life at all, he still remains subject to some danger or the other in this world. That there is no reason for being afraid if one adopts certain precautions and follows scientific procedures, should be widely made known.

Contraction of The Disease By The Workers

In spite of all this, the workers in this field of service should surrender themselves completely to God's will. With all the care taken and precautions observed if one contracts the disease due to association with leprosy victims one should be able to prepare ones mind to remain unruffled and accept it as "Prasad" - Gods blessing. To a worker having developed such a state of mind, even the disease can be turned to be advantageous. In our leprosy home at Dattapur, once, when I had an opportunity of talking to the patients, I took courage to render them solace by saying: "My brothers, you now already have the disease. What is ordained can not be avoided. But if you can accept your disease as a "prasad of God" (Grace and desire of God); your disease itself would become your instrument of emancipation in this worldly life. Our men of learning have taught us that what we really are is not the body we possess but the "Atman", the inner real being. This disease from which you are suffering could become helpful to you for such an inner realisation. Try to think deeply along this line". A few years after hearing what I had said one of the patients wrote to me that he had been trying to think along this line I had suggested and he derived considerable solace from doing so. If a patient can experience such solace by acceptance of the disease as God's will and grace, will it not be possible for a selfless worker to experience the same on contracting the disease if he does ?

Ideal Leprosy Homes

Leprosy service has to be conducted in two ways: (1) By establishing treatment centres or clinics at several places, (ii) By establishing leprosy homes at some places, I would not like to go into the discussion as to which of the two is more important. But I would like to be made known to you my thinking on one point with regard to the functioning of the Leprosy homes. Not

that there is something new in what I am suggesting, I am only speaking out what occurs to my mind in a few words. The patients of Leprosy Colonies should not say in despondency; "we deserve to be pitied upon and helped by the Society". They all undoubtedly deserve pitiful consideration and grace but the grace has be sought from God. In fact we all need such pitiful consideration and grace from God. When we serve the leprosy ridden persons we are not really doing any obligation or good to others but infact we are doing good to ourselves. This should essentially be our attitude. The atmosphere in the leprosy homes and colonies should be such as to make the patients develop faith and confidence in their own creative capacity. In short the leprosy colonies should try to create an atmosphere charged with the spirit for action, productive work towards self sufficiency, mutual co-operation, quest for knowledge and devotion to God.

(An All India Conference of workers in the field of leprosy was held at Wardha on 30th October 1947. Due to his inability to personally attend the conference Vinoba sent his address in writing which was read out at the Conference. The English translation from Hindi by Dr. R. P. Jyotishi, Manohardham Dattapur - Wardha)



SERVICE : THE HIGHEST FORM OF WORSHIP

This is what is named as Prem-Samaj You don't talk much when you are in love; you act. The mother does not tell her children that she loves them very much. She is constantly in action out of her love for them. You should therefore not expect a long talk from me here.

God is very much pleased with the kind of work you are doing here. No other activity is more satisfying to him than service to the people who are in misery. At several places programmes of service are carried out through the Ramkrishna Mission. The Christian Missions are known the worldover in this connection. But in India the programme of service to those in distress was taken up extensively for the first time by Ramkrishna Misson. The Christian Missions derived their inspiration for service from Jesus Christ. Jesus Christ was a "Bramhachari". A supreme lover of humanity, he used to personally go to other people in misery and his very touch restored back their peace. Inspired by this pious example of Jesus the Missionaries and devotees of Jesus Christ went all over the world in service to the humanity. The service rendered by the Christian Mission, however, has a motive attached from which they derive their inspiration. If this motive were not there, their service would have been all the more noble. They have a notion in their mind that their act of service out of love would be complete only when they convert people to the Christian faith. I do not blame them on this account. I would, however, say that, behind their service activity with this idea in their mind, there lies the motive of self gratification. If such a motive were not there, their action would have been all the more magnanimous. In any case whatever they have done is none the less magnanimous.

Ramkrishna-mission people derive their inspiration from the thought of "Adwait". It is a beautiful source they have got for their inspiration for service; but "Adwait" found an absolutely dry ground in India earlier. The believers in "Adwait" themselves became extremely inactive. Due to this, in India, love could not find its manifestation in human action through Adwait to the extent it found its manifestation through the "Bhaktimarg" -

the path of devotion. But here again, the draw-back remained that devotion could not be transformed to identify itself with service to the humanity. The believers in 'Adwait' have had love and respectful feeling for all but their religious pursuits found their culmination and endpoint in Meditation. Religion found its ultimate expression in idol worship. Meditation also remained limited to concentration through idol worship only. Worship as is done, is a dramatic ritual; God has to be awakened in the morning and so it is done. Then the drama of bathing, feeding and putting him to sleep, in the form of an idol, is performed regularly. This is really akin to a kindergarten, an example put forth through this ritual performed in the temple for every one in the village to follow in his normal living. If it was considered desirable that all the people in the village should wake up in the morning at 4 O' clock, they performed the ritual of waking the idol at 4 in the morning. If it was desired that the entire village community should take it's bath early in the morning at 6 A.M., the God in the temple also was made to do so at this time. If they wanted that every one in the village should take lunch at 12 noon regularly, God was also served his lunch at this time in the temple. If it was considered for the people of the village not to go to the movies and spoil their eye sight and sleep by 9 P.M., God in the temple also was put to bed at this fixed time. In this way people had evolved a method to discipline the life of every individual in the village. The objective behind all this, thus, was very good. As you go down south you observe this practice being commonly followed. In every village there is a big temple and this temple controls and regulates the living of the entire village community. All this was very good. But still, the 'Bhakti-marg' (Salvation through devotion and prayer) found it's end limit in the idol worship only. It did not manifest itself in service of fellow human beings in misery. Their service work was limited to the people constituting the family, and they considered this much service activity enough. The social condition now is such that this service activity limited to individual homes and families can not meet the requirement of the society in full and as a whole. How would you render service well in homes? A sick person is lying but there is not enough space for his bed. There is only one room in the house, which is also to be used as a kitchen, with lot of smoke all over. How can proper service be rendered to a sick person under such condition? Service activity carried out in individual homes, thus, does not meet with the requirement of

service of the Society as a whole in full. Therefore, 'Bhakti', the way of devotion and worship, should ultimately express itself in actual service to the fellow humans in misery. This however did not happen. A serious drawback thus persisted in our way of devotion and prayer, and as I said earlier, the believers in Adwait also remained dry and completely inactive. They would eat, because they had to as something unavoidable. They would go out for alms with a feeling of compulsion and helplessness. They believed that all such activities they had to perform were obstacles in their way to achieve their objective — attainment of their goal. A philosophy which downgraded and labelled all work and physical activity as something undesirable gained ground and this philosophy — vedant itself — became dry and lifeless. I admit that love finds its full unfoldment and expression in the heart and a full realisation of Adwait ultimately results in cessation of all outward physical activity. But persons reaching such state of realisation are rare; one in lakhs or crores. Their very presence can dispel human miseries. But on this account, if, all of those who believe in Adwait, become inactive and dry they will lose all their energy and force of living itself. With inspiration obtained from the philosophy of Adwait, human service was undertaken for the first time by Ramkrishna mission. It was also for the first time that social service programme was started in India as an act out of devotion and prayer by Mahatma Gandhi. The disciples of Ramkrishna in their Adwait activities, found the highest manifestation of love in form of human service. Mahatma Gandhi taught us that the meaning and essence of devotion to God lies in service to humanity at large. In this way in the present social era a good amount of experimentation and research has been done in these fields — Devotion (Bhakti) and the philosophy of Adwait. These persons belonging to the Prem Samaj, also belong to this tradition.

I want to emphasise that if people and similar organisations undertake several such service programmes the work to be carried out by the Government would be reduced. The Government, if it so desires, may render its support; it really should. But what should really happen is that all such social service programmes should be taken in hand by the voluntary Social Service Organisations which would reflect the collective determination of people. I would not elaborate this further because now I have reached the area of my topic for the general talk that I have to give.

What I want to impress is that, if every activity carried out by the Government is progressively taken up by the people, the Government can gradually be dissolved. This service programme is of the kind that can be easily taken up by the people of India. Their capacity in it's fullness can find it's best expression in such human service undertaken. But it can so happen only on one condition which has to be fulfilled. Service can not become an act of prayer until it is completely free from the element of ego - a feeling of self-glorification. The mother serves her child and the children do service to the mother. If it is completely free from ego and self-consciousness, this very service becomes an act of worship. But if the mother has the consciousness that it is her child that she is serving then it is just an act of ordinary service and not an act of worship. Service can be completely transformed in to God's worship of the highest kind if it is completely free from self-centered ego. The distressed and poor who come here should not feel that some good is being done to them as an act of benevolence. If they harbour such a feeling, then I would say that those who have rendered service to them were dominated with ego. We should have a deep inner feeling with it's actuality of experience that those persons whom we serve are not really "अनाथ", but they are really our "नाथ"-- the God himself. It is God himself who has appeared before us in their person. Similarly the patients also should not have a consciousness and feeling that some one as a person, named so and so, is serving them. They should have an inner feeling and realisation that it is God himself who has come to them for service in form of these social workers. If such a beauty can be incorporated in to service, service becomes a highest form of devotion and worship. Although I had no intention of speaking but still some ideas came to my mind and they have been offered to you. And, as I said I have now arrived at the point of the subject, the further elaboration of which would be done by me in my talk for general public.

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★ Address on the occasion of the Annual function of "PREM SAMAJ" at Vishakhapatnam Andhra Pradesh on 27.10.55. Translation from Hindi by Dr. R. P. Jyotishi, -Manohar dham - Dattapur - wardha.

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THE UNFINISHED WORK OF GANDHI

In the statistics presented to us it has been stated that there are in all about 25 lakh persons suffering from Leprosy in India. We don't know how far these figures are correct because of the fact that the tendency on the part of people to hide the disease is still persisting. If the doctors properly and effectively explain to the people that it is not at all desirable to hide this disease; its earliest possible cure is possible if it is brought to the notice of the doctors, as effective remedies of the disease are now known there should be no reason to lose hope on this account. Those who already have the disease, and also others, who are free from it, need now have no fear and a cause for hating the affected persons. Although every one says so but it is a fact that people still hide it from being known to others. The number of Leprosy infected persons in India, therefore, can be more than 25 Lakhs. There are in all 5 lakh villages in India, and in addition, there are some towns and cities. If we assume the total number to be around 6 lakhs, then, according to your estimate, there would be on an average 4 persons in each town or village - may be some more. The number would be less in some states while more in others.

I have been thinking that it would be easier for the Village-councils (Gram-Sabha) to deal with this problem. In other words leprosy service work should be carried out through these village councils. If Leprosy service work is so organised it would probably be easier as well as possible for us to reach every one in the Country. I give this advice for getting this work done through Village-council due to several reasons. If organisation of Village-council all over is too extensive a programme, it should be taken up as a programme in one's own limited area. You should not expect that organisation of Village-councils shall be taken up and carried out by some one else. Certainly there would be other persons who would organise these village councils; but you should not merely await the organisation of the village councils by others for starting your work. We, that is, you and all those engaged in leprosy service work also should be interested in the formation of these Village-councils and should devote your attention to it. If some time is lost in accomplishing this, it should be taken as time spent on leprosy service work itself.

If appears, this disease is of very old origin. In the present time several new diseases have now come up. A very big conference of medical men was held in Europe. All the doctor attending the conference unanimously put up a resolution for discussion stating: "It is astonishing to observe that the number of Doctors has increased tremendously but number of persons suffering from illness has also increased at the same time. Several diseases have also appeared anew. As a consequence of the modern civilization, numerous new diseases, even the names of which were unknown to the medicalmen of the past, have now become prevalent. What could possibly be done now in this regard under the present condition?" The diseases known since early history thus are already prevalent in good number, and, several new diseases, hitherto unknown, are continuously appearing. Leprosy is one of the diseases prevalent since olden times which have yet not been fully under control. Mention of this disease has also been made in the Vedas. Ghosha had suffered from this disease. Ghosha is reported to have prayed and invoked grace of God Ashwanikumar and thus became free from the disease. It has been so stated in Rigveda. Why Ghosha sought help of Ashwanikumar is simple to understand. Ashwanikumar was a well known physician of prehistoric times. He was a physician to the Devas. He must have given some medicine and must have also added prayer as an essential part of the treatment. With the help of both together Ghosha might have been cured. This is how the saying in Rigveda could be interpreted.

Thinking about prayer, I am reminded of a doctor who is at present sitting amongst you. He is about 80 years in age and is still engaged in leprosy service. I had an occasion to visit the institution run by him known as Tapovan. He has named this place as Tapovan. The place is indeed beautiful for persons suffering from Leprosy. There I read a sentence written somewhere "We Doctors only administer and prescribe medicines, but the diseases are cured by God." I have not forgotten this sentence as yet. It is correct to say that it is mainly prayer which cures one from diseases. Any medicine we take is only physical in effect. It is nowadays an accepted truth that the psychological factor, the state of the mind, plays an important part in treatment of physical ailments. 50% of the diseases can be cured through psychological methods of treatment. For the remaining part of them only medicines are applicable.

I look at the institutions run by the Missionaries with great respect. They do not believe in the use of medicines only.

They have a great deal of faith in the power of prayer as well. They sit near the patient and pray God with deepest concentration. It is a different matter that, some how, it is established in their mind that only those who completely surrender themselves to Jesus Christ can achieve their salvation, and not others. This wrong notion has become their firm mental conviction. On several occasions I have been trying to make them understand that if human salvation was possible through Christ alone – since Christ appeared in this world only two thousand years ago, and human beings have been inhabiting earth since the past ten lakh years – should it mean that, all those who lived prior to his times and after, are all condemned? This certainly is not possible. Therefore we should assume Christ as an impersonal human manifestation of God. It has also been said “Jesus for ever, yesterday, today, and for ever”. It means that he is an impersonal human being. In light of this, it should be possible to see that both the one who prays in the name of Rama and the one who offers his prayers in the name of Jesus Christ – if they do so with sincerity and devotion – will achieve salvation equally. I keep on explaining all this to them and I am happy to say that they are gradually accepting this idea. But I do not discredit them for their implicit faith in Christ. Their praying in the name of Christ, in my opinion, is an extremely good action on their part.

Question: How can leprosy service work be integrated with the constructive programme?

Answer: I do not expect you to help in the Gramdan movement. It is there as an essential duty for every one to take up. You are engaged in a magnanimous work and I think it would be too much to expect from you to devote yourself to any other such activity. I would however suggest that you should render your help in formation and organisation of Gram Sabhas (Village Council) and not in securing gramdan. That would be done by others. Since organisation of Gram Sabhas is essential for success in your work as well, I would say, it would be nice if you can render your help in that. I would not like to enburden you with any other programme of work in addition.

Question: Bapu had expressed that his work on leprosy control had remained incomplete. How this incomplete work can now be executed during this Centenary of Mahatma Gandhi securing co-operation and help from the Government employees as well as various institutions.

Answer: It would be very painful if this magnanimous

and pious programme of work is left to the Government and its different organisations. If any conflict and difference of opinion exists among different organisations, it would be a very unfortunate situation. I hope all organisations that are formed shall co-operate with each other and shall be complementary among themselves. This is what should really happen. I am told that formation of this institution has created a sense of separateness and distance. This is not what should happen. It is meaningless because we have before us a challenging task. There would be no harm under the present situation if institutions more than one are organised. But co-operation among them certainly must increase.

With regard to several work programmes left unfinished by Gandhiji, which are many, children always get born to execute them. In fact children are those who have to take up and complete the unfinished work. (Here in the use of the words 'Children' and 'leftout work' - 'Bachche' and 'Bacha kam' there is a delightful play on words typical of Vinoba). This is what I take as the very meaning of the words (Bachche and 'Bacha Kam'). We have accepted Gandhi as the Father of the nation. We are all thus Children. Work in several fields has been left unfinished by him which we have to undertake and complete. Leprosy service is one of them. But it would be a most dangerous thing if we only depend upon this centenary, as the emphasis in it is not so much on Gandhi as on Centenary. That means the enthusiasm was not there during the 99th year and it would all end by the 102th year. It is thus really an importance given to mathematical numbers only. We may have all celebration and commotion during this centenary celebration period and may then slow down our efforts by the next. This is not right. It is true that people derive a bit greater inspiration from the centenary and their cooperation is available in larger measure which is rather difficult in normal period. We should therefore certainly take advantage of this cooperation and enthusiasm for our work. I must however say that all that which is being done in the name of Centenary is in danger. I have therefore drawn your attention toward it.

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Address delivered by Vinoba Bhave on the Occasion of second conference of the National Leprosy Organisation on November 14, 1969. Translation from Hindi by Dr. R. P. Jyotishi, Manohardham, Dattapur, Wardha. ★

LEPROSY PATIENTS ARE STATUES OF GOD

An inclination towards silence is growing within me these days ; but still some time has been allotted for me to speak to you. Experts in the field of Leprosy service have gathered here in large number. In addition, several experts in the field of medicine have also come. I should serve on you a show cause notice as to why you have expected me to say some thing to a group of such experts in your field; but I would not do so. Love is after all blind and such unusual happenings occur due to that. According to some poet, a talk before experts by a layman is some thing like a child singing in front of Narad. Even then let it be so. I have just obtained a detailed account of what is being done in Maharashtra in the field of Leprosy through a paper. I did not have so much information regarding this before. Although I have been moving around in our country for the last thirteen or fourteen years and have had the occasion to visit a number of leprosy institutions in several places in the country, I had no idea that work is being carried out on such an extensive scale. I therefore thank all the workers and the Government who are engaged in this work.

I was thinking in my mind as to what should I say before you all. I have read the pamphlet brought out by the Government of Maharashtra. In the preface written by Shri Bhardeji all that is necessary to be said has all been said already. There is need for extensive dissemination of information; there is need for making contact with people in extensive area through visits to villages – all such nice things have already been mentioned and really there is nothing left for me to say.

But these days there is a big problem society at large is confronted with. Although leprosy service work is being carried on every where, Europe, U. S. A. India, China, Japan etc, to some extent or the other, the number of persons suffering has also been increasing. Is not this mysterious ? That the human population itself is growing largely is not the only reason. The rate at which the number of patients is increasing is more than the rate of increase of the population. But I don't see anything new in this. Sometime back a conference of reputed medical men was held in Europe for discussion not only on leprosy but

on all human diseases. At this conference all these medical men together agreed that Civilization is advancing, many new diseases are also growing. It is not understood what this mystery is. If the doctors themselves can not understand this riddle how can others do ?

Innumerable new diseases are coming up. This programme of 're-construction' is going on all over. It has to be taken as a subject belonging to the domain of culture. New civilization and culture have brought with them many nice things and one of these is also this increase in the number of patients. This is not so with Leprosy only. If we look at the world at large we find that all together numerous kinds of diseases are growing. What to do about it is a big problem we are facing. A number of persons have suggested numerous measures and all those should indeed be adopted. But above all these I would like to place prayer as number one in priority and importance both from the point of view of patients as well as workers engaged in service. In 'Charak Sanhita' it has been mentioned that if a man is suffering from a deadly disease, recitation of "Vishnu Sahasra-nam" is more effective than treatment with medicines. Chark Sanhita is a treatise on the Ayurvedic System of medicine and treatment. It is not a religious book but this is what is mentioned in it.

I have myself witnessed such prayers being held with this purpose. Where-ever service to the diseased is undertaken by the Christian missionaries, they go and sit near the patients and offer prayers. This is customary with them and they do this with great faith. We are adopting and should certainly adopt all new methods and measures made known to us with the advancement of science, but I feel, prayer is of much greater value and importance than all those.

I had my first acquaintance with these patients in 1936 when Manoharji started his leprosy service work here at Dattpur. Although I had observed them sitting on roads earlier but I looked into their faces for the first time at this institution. Two years after, in 1938, I came to Paunar. While digging the soil here we unearthed some stone statues. I myself also got one while I was digging the soil. All these statues were 1300 to 1400 years old and their faces appeared exactly like those of the leprosy victims. Because of being left buried in the soil for 1400 years, some of them have got their noses disfigured while others have

got their hands mutilated. Whenever I see any one suffering from leprosy I am reminded of these statues. I have a feeling that these are the statues of God and if some one were to carve out such beautiful statues anew they will not invoke such a devotional feeling towards them in me. I have got a very great regard for leprosy service and when I see a person suffering from Leprosy I visualise before me these statues of Paramdham.

Any one engaged in leprosy service should have a feeling in him that he is only instrumental and the patient he is serving is God personified ; that God has himself appeared before him in form of the patient to receive his services. Once I went to this leprosy home and expressed my desire to work with the patients. I did some agricultural work of sowing etc. in the fields with them. I can not express in words the joy I felt while doing so. God alone knows whether our service helps in curing their disease or not but it is definite that we would achieve our own salvation through our service rendered to them. Leprosy service should be done with such a conviction and feeling for emancipation of our soul. Fortunately we have amongst us persons doing leprosy service with such feeling. Baba Amte is sitting right in front. Dr. Patwardhan is also here. They are completely engrossed in leprosy service physically, mentally as well as verbally. They don't think that they are obliging any one by doing so. They feel that they are only obliging themselves. It is God's blessing on India that such persons have been born here.

Earlier such persons were born among Christians only. The reason behind this is Jesus Christ. It is stated in Bible that a number of persons suffering from leprosy got free from the disease merely by the touch of hand by Jesus Christ. That is the reason why Christians regard leprosy service as service to God and Jesus himself. This is why they completely absorb themselves with great devotion in their service. We did not believe in this earlier. Now we have started in believing so.

It is surprising that we have had no derth of philosophical thinking in India. The greatest in philosophical thought – the philosophy of "Adwait" (Monoism) was born here. What else beyond 'Adwait' could now be thought of ? But inspite of this, a sense of differentness, isolation, a feeling for discremination has all along been reflected in our behaviour. It is astonishing how

this happened. If the attitude of service to humanity derived from the Christian religion and the idea of "Adwait" from Hinduism could be combined together an atmosphere of greatest joy could be created.

The first to recognise this was Swami Vivekanand. Vivekanand belonged to the "Shanker" sect and believed in "Adwait". He combined this idea of "Adwait" with the ideal of service in Christianity. I have myself observed at several places that the Ramkrishna Mission has done excellent service work. With the combination of the best of the thoughts contained in the Hindu and Christian religions this new philosophic context that has emerged is really unique in itself. In a similar manner taking exquisite thoughts from all the different religions we have to synthesise a comprehensive religion, all perfect in itself. From this point of view Swami Vivekanand has made really a very great contribution.

There are several other persons – the lame and the blind – who are also suffering like those ridden with leprosy. They also need service. Thus there is a large section of people who are in need of care and help. If we take into account all such miserable and tormented persons who are absolutely helpless and completely dependent on service by others, they add up to a very large number. The population of India is 55 crores. There would be thus at least 55 lakhs of such people constituting this section. There is a prayer mentioned in the Vedas: "Oh God bestow the ability to walk to the lame, and vision to the blind." It is not merely the normal capacity to see things as we ordinarily can that the Vedic sage is praying for the blind. It is for a vision of God. But this may happen later, whenever it does. But, for the present, if the normal sight could be revived in case of the blind it would be a substantial advantage. There is a bhajan of Surdas in which he expresses bewilderment at the strange happenings in this World as God's "Leela" (Playful act) He says "It is his habit to keep on doing some such things strange like this : " "उघो करमन की गति न्यारी ।" "There are people endowed with large and good eyes but they have no craving for seeing God. On the other hand Surdas is blind and you have given him such an urge and desire to see God in person. How strangely you act ?" "मूरख मूरख राजा कीन्हे पंडित फिरत भिखारी" "You have made fools as Kings while

those who are learned ara begging.” And at the end he writes —
“सुर श्याम मिलन की आशा छिन छिन बीतत भारी”

Thus from vedic times until the era of Surdas a very deep feeling has been prevailing here that service to the blind and lame is really the service to God. But this was not actually acted upon in practice. Christians however put this into actual practice.

Those religions which have had religious teachers—‘Gurus’ acquired certain special characteristic features according to the special trait of the Guru himself. The Jains are imparted with the speciality of observance of fasts because Mahavir, their religious teacher, spent half his life observing fasts only. Tas is, in his life, he fasted for almost as many days as he took his food. The fasts he observed also were such that he did not even take water. Once, in connection with ‘Satyagraha,’ the idea regarding fast was suggested and discussed. I said let it not be the fast of the Jains, because people would say that this is an observance related to a religions practice ; it is no Satyagraha. In short the special feature of the life of the religious gurus (teachers) is acquired by the followers. Thus as the speciality of observance of fasts of jain teachers is reflected in Jains, tradition of service has appeared as the special trait among the Christians.

Now how would you manage to take care of this large section of people needing service and help ? How would it be done ? The only answer in my mind to this is :

ग्रामे ग्रामे सभा कार्या

ग्रामे ग्रामे शुभ कथा

Village – council in every village and frequent good discourses every where.

This ‘Shloka’ is from Pt. Madan Mohan Malviya. He suggested this to me when I once met him. Good religious discourses should be frequently held in every village and the village council in each should be organised. This programme concerning service to the patients and their rehabilitation should be undertaken for execution by the Gram Sabha. Unless the responsibility is taken up by the Gram Sabha the execution of the programme from the upper levels only will not result in success. There is a saying in Marathi language :
“उंटावरून शेल्या हाकणारा”

(The heardman managing his grazing goats sitting on a Camel). For effectively managing the grazing goats, the heardman has to come down on the ground. How can a person sitting in a high position on a Camel graze his goats properly ? Similarly how can the leprosy programme be executed by persons sitting and directing from higher levels ? Those who are actually members of the Gram Sabha should themselves take up this responsibility and arrange for rehabilitation of the patients. All the necessary information required should then be extended to the people through village teachers and others. In this manner a continued programme of dissemination of knowledge regarding leprosy should be conducted to dispel the prevalent unnecessary fear regarding the disease. People die more often due to fear of the disease than the disease itself. The biggest disease is fear. Many diseases originate out of fear. Once the thought "I must be having this" comes to the mind disease invariably must appear. This problem arising out of fear must be tackled. This is the reason why in Gita among traits of Godliness, freedom from fear has been given the first place. The unnecessary fear held by the patients as well as the society is not proper. We are not generally afraid of what we should really be afraid of. We are not afraid of uncleanness. We have maintained it and unnecessarily we hold fear in us for what we should not. Therefore all this work should be undertaken by the Gram Sabha only. In the pamphlet published by the Maharashtra State Government it has been stated that in forty thousand villages, i. e. 75%, this information has been disseminated and provision for injection against the disease has been made. It is good that the necessary arrangement to provide injections has been made. But all this programme should be executed through the Gram-Sabha only which means the entire responsibility for work in the village should be shouldered by the Gram Sabha itself. Each village should be self-sufficient. There should be "Gram-Swaraj" in every village. Without "Gram Swaraj" this work can not be accomplished.



The second Conference of the Workers of the Maharashtra State engaged in Leprosy Service was held in Wardha on 28th & 29th November 1970. Address of Vinoba to the workers at Pavnar on 27th evening. Translation by Dr. R. P. Jyotishi, Manohardham - Dattapur.



THREE SOCIAL EVILS

Ordinarily, when I am required to speak to a gathering, I don't do any prethinking before speaking. Looking at the faces of the people in the audience, whatever comes to my mind, I just speak out at the spur of the moment. I am very happy to see that doctors working in the field, from Assam right up to Kerala are present here. This is the first occasion of this kind. The problem before me is as to what I should say? My friend Manoharji has shown me the reprints of all my speeches I have made so far on Leprosy service and I find that there is nothing new left for me to say on the subject now.

Four aspects of service work to the afflicted :-

I felt an inspiration for "Bhoodan Yagna" and I have spent about twenty five years of my life working with this objective. I went round the entire country walking on foot from village to village and also travelled extensively by train and motor vehicles. This gave me an opportunity to meet with a large number of people at different places. I visited all the leprosy service centres that came on my way, leaving not even one where I did not go. At each of these centres I explained what we have to do in this regard. Every where I stressed that Gram Sabha should be organised in every village which should shoulder the responsibility of leprosy service. And what did I mean by this responsibility? I tried to explain that, just as in the traditional way of teaching Hindi alphabates to the children in our schools, we have what we call the 'Barakhadi' - 'Ba', 'Baa', 'Bi', 'Bee', 'Bu', 'Boo', we have five types of persons in our villages who need help and special care, and they are 'Bachche' (Children) 'Budhe' (Old Persons), 'Bewa' (Widows), 'Bekar' (Unemployed) and 'Beemar' (suffering from illness). Every village council has to take care of these five categories of people, the five 'Bas' as I call them. In every village there are some children who are orphans, there are persons who are old and who have no one else to fall back upon, there are widows with no other relatives to take care of them all. It is for the Gram-Sabha to look after all these and take their proper care. The Gram Sabha should shoulder the responsibility of looking after all those persons of the village who are afflicted

with serious ailments and also for providing remunerative work to those who are unemployed. Among the physical ailments, I have listed, in order of priority, Leprosy is number one followed by the lame and those who have lost their hands, the blind, and lastly, those suffering from Tuberculosis. There are others also besides these but it is mainly these five types of persons whose responsibility shall have to be undertaken by the village community itself.

Part of the work in this connection shall be done by the Village council; some part shall be undertaken by the Government, some by the Doctors and some by the social workers. I have here drawn your attention to the responsibility that the village community has to undertake.

A number of doctors who have been inspired for service work by the grace of God and who are engaged in such work in various parts of the Country have assembled here. I have been gratified to see that the Government is also doing as much as it can in this field of service activity. The report of work done by the Maharashtra State Government in the field of leprosy service which I have received gives an idea of the number of service centres started at different places and also some account of the actual work being carried out. It gives the impression that quite some efforts are being made by the Government. I have told the sevaks, the voluntary social workers, that it is their job to extend the required knowledge about leprosy to every person in our villages. How many sevaks in all we have? My estimate is that there would be in all about ten thousand of them who are working in our villages. But the total number of villages in India is 5 lakhs. Even at the rate of one Sevak for a population of 5 lakhs we need a minimum of one lakh sevaks for this work. And we have at present, in all, only 10 thousand, that is, only 10% of the total requirement. May God inspire many more persons for undertaking this service work so that we have a much bigger group of Sevaks working in this field. I have been my-self doing my best so that this number increases and this group of Sevaks is enlarged further. So far I have tried to give you a picture of what is being done, how much has to be done and how much could be done.

The three evils of the society :

Your complaint- and certainly a very right complaint - is

that this disease is growing further day by day. In India alone there are in all about 30 lakhs leprosy patients. In a population of 5 crores there are 30 lakhs persons suffering from Leprosy. After 2 years another 4 lakhs would be added. (There is an increase going on every day). It is quite natural for you to be worried about this. It should, however, be understood that the diseases – not only leprosy but other diseases as well – are all increasing because of the three evils prevailing in our society. The society is afflicted with these three evils.

Improper Nutrition :

The first evil we are afflicted with is mal-nutrition. Forty percent of the population in our country is not getting the minimum requirement by way of food nutrition – the minimum nutrition required to keep the body and soul together. There is a severe lack of nutrition prevalent. This is the reason why it has been said in the Upanishads: “अन्नं बहु कुर्वीत । तद् व्रतम्” – Produce more food; take a vow to do so. This is said in the Upanishads – which is not a publication of the five year plans. The Upanishad has been concerned with what the Five year plans are concerned with because the Upanishad knows fully well that “अन्नं ब्रह्मेति व्यजानात्” the very first Bramhan is food and so it should be thought of first. The Upanishad there after says “प्राणो ब्रह्मेति व्यजानात्” – the second Bramhan is – प्राण – the life principle. Then – मनो ब्रह्मेति व्यजानात् – the third Bramhan is the mind. There after follows: ‘विज्ञानं ब्रह्मेति व्यजानात् and आनन्दो ब्रह्मेति व्यजानात्।’

“There are five Bramhans in sequence of importance. Joy as Bramhan is mentioned as the last and food as the very first. Every one knows: “मूखे भजन न होइ गोपाला” “It is not possible to pray God with an empty stomach.” Lord Buddha’s disciple Anand once brought a person for enlightenment to Buddha. Buddha remarked that the person appeared to be hungry. The person on being asked said that he did not have his food for the last three days. Buddha asked Anand to first go and feed the man. Any preaching if necessary would only be done later. Buddha has taught us that no preaching, no spiritual teaching, is of any avail to a person who is hungry, who has nothing to quench his hunger for food. Food shortage is a problem, not only of India or Asia; it is a problem the whole world is facing. With the

advancement of science all countries of the World are getting closer together and therefore Baba feels that it is the solemn duty of one and all in the world, in-fact the entire humanity at large, to help in solving the problem of food. Food shortage is a very prominent cause of the growing diseases.

Uncontrolled self-indulgence :

The second evil our society is inflicted with is uncontrolled and over indulgence. Our theaters, cinema, literature are all full of so much filth that, it is difficult to keep one's mind and consciousness pure and clean. All the time that Ravan—the loud speaker—keeps on blaring out every where. It's on-slaught is on your ears and inspite of your dislike for them, filthy words are constantly being poured down your ears. The result is that your very consciousness—your mind—gets polluted and corrupt. The growth in the population is the consequence of this corruption. If the population keeps on growing like this, in 30 years time, there would be twice as many people populating this world. The population of India would be 110 crores in place of the present 55 crores. It would not be less than 100 crores by 2001AD. The result of this would be that the land available would fall short of the requirement. The number dying out of hunger would further increase. But I am not afraid of this growth and increase in population. If procreation is a consequence of religious living and activity the resultant progeny would be that of truthful and brave persons and the earth would not feel their burden on itself. But this increase in the population that is taking place, is the consequence and result of an undisciplined over indulgence. 'Grahasthashram' -(family living) is taken to be a license for uncontrolled sexual activity. You must have heard the name of Kishorilal Bhai (Mashruwala). In course of my talk with him once I had pointed out what all our saints—Narsi Mehta, Tukaram and many others—have said in this regard. Narsimehta says that you should look at other person's wife as your mother: "परस्त्रीजेने मातरे".

Tukaram also says the same thing "पराविया नारी-माऊली समान" I then asked him, why is it that all these saints applauded the persons who have had no relationship with other person's wife but none of them talked about Bramhacharya, self-control. Kishori Bhai in reply said that I had no knowledge

about the present day society. It would really be surprising if you could find even one man with family out of a thousand who has had no such relationships with the wife of some other person. What else could be expected as consequence of this? Diseases will be on the increase both in their number and intensity as 'Gods will' :

Pollution of the air :

The third evil is pollution of the air. Rivers are getting polluted so much so that when they reach up to the ocean even the ocean gets polluted resulting in some fish leaving coastal waters and others getting killed. Fish now are not available in areas of thousand of miles. Vegetation has been poisoned, air has been polluted. There is a new field of Science which has come up, known as Ecology. Ecology is concerned with keeping the surrounding atmosphere clean and in good condition. There is more of this pollution of air in America than in India. There is more cleanliness maintained on the ground level there but the air all over has become unclean. They don't know what to do about it. A number of newer diseases are cropping up as a result of this. A conference of doctors from all over Europe and America was once held. A resolution was adopted in this conference in which it was stated that with the increase of doctors the number of diseases are also increasing. Diseases which were unknown so long and are not mentioned in the medical literature at all are appearing now. One can't understand the reason why it is so happening. When the doctors themselves can't understand the reason why who else could understand? Pollution of the air is the third reason for this situation. If diseases keep on increasing due to these three evils would you just sit and feel helpless? This really should not make you lose hope and confidence in your work of service. When I came to know that my father would not remain alive for more than ten days and would die on the 9th day, I did not stop tending him, I felt it as my duty to render service to him till his last breath. What purpose does this serve? Satisfaction to the self. Then if you make your service an offering to God you would yourself attain your own salvation. But until we are able to become free from these evils we shall not be able to make the world free from diseases.

Importance of prayer :

Now a word of his own from Baba. I remember a sentence

- I read some time back - most probably it is from Tennyson although I am not sure, "More things are wrought by prayer than World dreams of". A lot can be achieved through prayer. Therefore we should render care and service to the sick and we should also sit by their side and offer our prayers to God. Words uttered as prayer, when find entry in to the ears of the diseased, would help in his cure or if the patients dies he would meet a peaceful end. His soul will rest in peace. This is the reason why Baba recites 'Vishnusahasranam' every day. Our oldest treatise on medicine also says the same thing. If it is known that the disease is bearable than we should sit by side of the patient and recite 'Vishnusahasranam'. By doing so he will get cured of the disease if possible, if not, he will die peacefully. Such a directive has been given to us in our books of religion-books such as Bible. Such directive is not found in our medical books in general. In 'Charak Sanhita' which is a prominent Indian treatise on medicine, however, the efficacy of 'Vishnusahasranam' in this regard has been mentioned. That is the reason why I advocate that every one should recite 'Vishnusahasranam' as prayer to God and should also make the persons suffering from the disease do the same.



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